Dark Daughter

By Nicole Blackman

INTRODUCTION

**According to the Medical Director of the Child Mind Institute, Harold Koplewicz, in the US, 17 million young people have been diagnosed with a mental heal disorder by the age of 18. Girls, in particular, are struggling. The CDC reports that in 2021 one in three had seriously contemplated suicide – an increase of 60 percent in 10 years. But despite the growing numbers, few seek care or support due to the deeply ingrained stigma that still surrounds mental health treatment.*

In Dark Daughter by Nicole Blackman, we are allowed into a personal and very frank conversation the speaker has with her mother. The words are dark, often brutal, but undeniably an honest insight into her struggle.

Dark Daughter by Nicole Blackman.

(Pg 88+) I am not of this family, I know that now and

I am not of your skin.

When you slit your wrists, you bled red.

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When I slit mine, I bled mud,

You and your pills will search for me search for my salvation,

will question the beginning of when I first fell and

offer explanations to explain me away.

The cloak of *the neighbors, the neighbors*

is all that causes you to quiet me.

No, you never ask about these brain movies.

No, you never talk me down from the balcony.

I count steps (sixteen from closet to bed)

and breaths taken in a day.

Cold numbers are warm comfort to me

as you can no longer comfort your dark daughter.

Every morning I am a new me and

select my persona from a deep closet.

I swoop down stairs

on fire, on stage.

Stop accusing me mother, I did not choose this.

No human hopes for a touch of mercury on the mind.

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Some people don't go crazy.
Some of us were always there.
While you were having breakfast I was having visions
and I am slowly being rocked away from you.

Me, this baby that still wails away with no cause.
I am slowly being rocked away from you.
Four years ago, in the middle of dinner, I interrupted
and said
Pardon Me, But I Can Feel Pain In The Ends Of My Hair.

You put down your fork then, you put down your fork
and fixed your attention on a girl grown wild
when you weren't looking.
Take away my hands, they weigh too much.
This body is not me, it's just where I live for a while.

I am more lucid when I give in
and I disintegrate regularly.
The crazier I am the stronger I am.
Feel the cells shift.
Listen to the bones slide.

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You hold me like a kite with a too long string.
Once I hit sky you'll let go.
I've begun my descent into self, into soul.
I've begun my descent and everything's fine
I've begun my descent and can't get off of the train.
I've begun my descent and you cannot come with me.

I look up to the showerhead, waiting for water.
Cold shock hits hard and slams night through
bones and skin and soul and brain and what was me.
Shudder and tremble and grasping the railing.

Damn your therapies
that leave me gasping
that turn me twice before I talk
leaving me with a long longing.
Self-help therapy helps no one.

Notebooks will not help me spew disease.
Medication cannot get me out of my head.
You cannot liberate me from this.
I am this.

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With a delicious shove I went over.

And you are lucky, mother, you are lucky.
I don't know the reason I am the way I am
so I wander round the house without a map
saying *I am not this, I am not that,* but I do not know
what I am.

The doctors define me by saying what my problem is
not
but throw up their hands when faced with a brain
beyond the radar, a gray lump more formidable
than their garden of books.

Give me some quality time with a trio of experts
tops in their field.
Don't hold me down, I'm not doing anything.
I'm just thinking.

I ask angels for prayers to string into a necklace and
wear round my neck.
I lean against walls waiting for the day
when they open up and I fall in.

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I am light with an awful lightness and drum my way
through night.

I am not rid of this fungus, all the doctors will not cut it
away.
No surgeon will open my brain and let the wrong leak
out.
If they drill my skull the demons might escape
might take hold of their million dollar hands,
might hold on and bite down hard.

Don't you wish I was an abortion, mother?
Don't you churn at night and wish you had the choice
again?
Don't you dream of laying a pillow on my face
and throwing me out with the trash in the morning?

I will rise up at midnight.
I will rise up and put on my wings to sweep over you.
I will rise up and hover in sky, in night.
I will rise up and forgive you your trespasses.

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Use your hands and get me out of the straps.
Sign the forms and set me free.
Say you do not understand me, but you believe me, mother.
Release me from this white white white room unlike heaven.

Brain highways lead back to spine, back to the problem.
I'm crawling out of this wrecked car
but no one really wants to see me get up and walk away.
Trying to think takes up too much time.

The most the doctors hope for is to discover that my lunacy is new
is nameable with my last name, is discoverable for their medical books.
I might be an award, I might be an article, I might be a non-profit organization.
I might be noble but I am a loss to everyone involved.

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If the bad side of you kills
and takes over the good side
is it a little murder?
Would anyone notice?

The neighbors say
We're so *sorry to hear that*
your daughter's brains
are dripping out her ears.

Am I crazy?
I am free with a horrifying freedom
and my world is full of flowers
and flame.

My typewriter scurries in the middle of the floor like a rat
and the bedsheets rise up, waves in a cold ocean.
Moonbeams are crystal bars that nail me to the bed
and cobwebs vibrate into scary nets for when I fall.

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I am a thirty foot spire of unhuman girlstone
standing on top of the shoulders of unclaimed ghosts.
I am everything you fear
you will become.

Crash through queen glass and say I was right all along.
Rock this skeleton that has no use for blood or sense.
Throw stones at me so I can build a crazy house.
Stuff me with paper so I am full of nothing and
therefore new.

I want to shave my head. Get closer to the shrine.
Find out why this globe at the top of my body
rules the rest of me so wrong.
I want to touch the disease. I want to know where I've
been hit.

I have nothing to miss, no memories to wander over.
I rub my arms over the spackled walls and
wait for them to tip over
become floor, become sky.

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You come up to my room
quietly, on the pretense of a lie
and touch the door
with scared, careful hands.

You want your heavy heart
to be relieved of 110 pounds
of bad choices
and bad memories.

This little problem is mine
I'll give it a name
I'll give it somewhere to stay
I'll take care of it.

I'll watch it grow up and take over
I'll take care of it now because I can
I guess that makes me my own little mother,
mother.

Don't try to open the door, mother, this poem is all
mine.
Finally, something is mine and makes sense.

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With a delicious shove, I go over again.
Big words reach up!

I swim over that wet line
and keep swimming.
I dig fingernails into stars
and feel my feet lightly brush planets.

Drummers thunder in my skull because there is no heartbeat
to confuse them. The thumps rock me against chair.
Color TV hums. Pillow shreds. Window releases.
Cat opens mouth, spits out bible.

I will come back in splinters
in blood in your hand.
I am looking through lightbulbs
and the storms keep coming.
The walls are crawling now, the candles are cracked.
I am listening for my breath in the paper.
Am clean, on fire.
Feels like water breaking.

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All this is sleek and cut and fast.
I am to go free.
I am throwing up snow
I am spitting out keys.
This is a hate house
and you're breathing me in
you're breathing this sickness in.
Now I'm inside you again.

It's time to go and
all my words make me strong

Mother, I'm already gone.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier - MS
CO State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

**** Source Information for Statistics in the Introduction***
https://www.mckinsey.com/mhi/our-insights/getting-to-the-bottom-of-the-teen-mental-health-crisis

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